

“The Soviet people want full-blooded and unconditional democracy.”

MIKHAIL GORBACHEV IN A JULY 1988 SPEECH

11 March 1985

MIKHAIL GORBACHEV LEADS THE USSR

On the death of Konstantin Chernenko, the USSR's governing Politburo turned to the reformer Gorbachev to fill the role of General Secretary of the ruling Communist Party. The choice was to have dramatic results, as Gorbachev's policy of *glasnost* or openness encouraged debate, whittling away the power of the Party and hastening the break-up of the Soviet Union.



△ Mikhail Gorbachev



1984

31 October 1984 Indira

Gandhi, India's first female prime minister, is assassinated by her own bodyguards



△ Refugees fleeing Ethiopia

1984

FAMINE STRIKES IN ETHIOPIA

With three-quarters of the population living as subsistence farmers, famine was a constant risk in Ethiopia. In the early 1980s, a bitter civil war and the repressive policies of the ruling military junta made life even more precarious. In 1984, the failure of the spring rains caused widespread starvation, particularly in the rebel northern province of Tigray. Despite international aid efforts, including the Live Aid fundraising campaign, half a million people are thought to have died.



△ Corazon Aquino at a victory rally

25 February 1986

PRESIDENT MARCOS OF THE PHILIPPINES IS TOPPLED

Ferdinand Marcos had ruled the Philippines for over 20 years, but when the economy declined from 1983, attention turned to the corruption underlying his rule. After opposition leader Benigno Aquino was assassinated later that year, his widow, Corazon, became the focus for a resistance movement. This culminated in the People Power Revolution that drove Marcos into exile and established Corazon as president.